

Ser vs. Estar — Beginner Reference

Crescere | Beginner Spanish | Week 2 Reference

Before You Start

English uses one word — "to be" — for almost everything. Spanish uses two: *ser* and *estar*.

This is not a quirk to memorize around. It is a real distinction that Spanish speakers feel, and you will learn to feel it too. It takes more than one week. The course returns to this topic throughout A1, and every time it will make a little more sense.

This handout is a reference — something to keep nearby while you practice. It is not a memorization sheet, and you are not expected to have it mastered before Week 2 begins.

The Core Idea

Verb	Use it for	Think of it as
<i>ser</i>	Who you are — identity, origin, profession, nationality	"What defines you"
<i>estar</i>	How you are — location, emotions, temporary states, conditions	"What describes your current situation"

Neither of these rules covers every case. They are starting points.

Side-by-Side Comparison

What you want to say	Use	Example	English
Name	<i>ser</i>	<i>Me llamo Ana. Soy Ana.</i>	My name is Ana.
Origin	<i>ser</i>	<i>Soy de Buenos Aires.</i>	I'm from Buenos Aires.
Profession	<i>ser</i>	<i>Soy profesora.</i>	I'm a teacher.
Nationality	<i>ser</i>	<i>Somos mexicanos.</i>	We're Mexican.
Essential description	<i>ser</i>	<i>El cielo es azul.</i>	The sky is blue.
Time / day / date	<i>ser</i>	<i>Son las tres. Es lunes.</i>	It's three o'clock. It's Monday.
Location (where something is)	<i>estar</i>	<i>Madrid está en España.</i>	Madrid is in Spain.
Emotion or feeling	<i>estar</i>	<i>Estoy contenta.</i>	I'm happy.
Temporary physical state	<i>estar</i>	<i>Estoy cansado.</i>	I'm tired.
Condition of an object	<i>estar</i>	<i>El café está frío.</i>	The coffee is cold.

High-Frequency Examples to Know

These are the sentences you will use most in Weeks 1 and 2. Know them by heart.

Ser:

- *Soy de Nueva York.* — I'm from New York.
- *Soy profesor / profesora.* — I'm a teacher.
- *Soy americano / americana.* — I'm American.
- *Somos estudiantes.* — We're students.
- *Es la una.* — It's one o'clock.

Estar:

- *Estoy cansado / cansada.* — I'm tired.
- *Estoy bien, gracias.* — I'm fine, thanks.
- *Estoy en casa.* — I'm at home.
- *El café está frío.* — The coffee is cold.
- *Madrid está en España.* — Madrid is in Spain.
- *¿Dónde está el baño?* — Where is the bathroom?

One that surprises people: Location always uses *estar* — even when the location feels permanent. *La Torre Eiffel está en París.* The Eiffel Tower is in Paris. Not *es*.

Meaning-Changing Adjectives

Some adjectives mean one thing with *ser* and something different with *estar*. This is one of the most interesting features of Spanish — and one of the most vivid illustrations of why the distinction matters.

You will practice these in Week 2, Session 4. For now, just read through them once.

Adjective	With <i>ser</i>	With <i>estar</i>
<i>aburrido/a</i>	<i>Es aburrido.</i> — He's boring (that's his personality).	<i>Está aburrido.</i> — He's bored (right now).
<i>listo/a</i>	<i>Es lista.</i> — She's clever (she's a smart person).	<i>Está lista.</i> — She's ready (ready to go).
<i>bueno/a</i>	<i>Es buena persona.</i> — She's a good person (kind).	<i>Está bueno.</i> — It's delicious (the food tastes good).
<i>seguro/a</i>	<i>Es un barrio seguro.</i> — It's a safe neighborhood.	<i>Estoy seguro.</i> — I'm certain / I'm sure (of something).

The key insight: *ser* describes what something *is*, *estar* describes how something *is right now*. With meaning-changing adjectives, the difference is everything.

Common Beginner Mistakes

Using *soy* for emotions. Wrong: *Soy cansado.* ✗ Correct: *Estoy cansado.* ✓ Emotions and temporary states always use *estar*.

Using *es* for location. Wrong: *Madrid es en España.* ✗ Correct: *Madrid está en España.* ✓ Location — of people, places, and objects — always uses *estar*.

Translating directly from English. English uses "is" for everything. Spanish does not. The question is never "what does 'is' translate to?" The question is "what am I describing — identity or current state?"

Trying to memorize one rule. No single rule covers all uses of *ser* and *estar*. Students who try to reduce it to one sentence get confused by the exceptions. The course builds your intuition over time — that is the right approach.

Practice

Choose *ser* or *estar*, or fill in the correct form. Answers are at the bottom.

1. Yo ____ de Colombia. (*Where I'm from*)
 2. Ella ____ médica. (*Her profession*)
 3. ¿Dónde ____ el supermercado? (*Location*)
 4. Hoy yo ____ muy cansado/a. (*How I feel today*)
 5. El agua ____ fría. (*Condition of the water*)
 6. Nosotros ____ americanos. (*Our nationality*)
 7. La farmacia ____ al lado del banco. (*Where it is*)
 8. Él ____ aburrido. (*He is boring — his personality*)
 9. Tú ____ lista para la clase. (*You are ready — prepared*)
 10. Son las ocho. El café ____ caliente. (*Condition of the coffee*)
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Answer key:

1. soy — origin → *ser*
 2. es — profession → *ser*
 3. está — location → *estar*
 4. estoy — temporary feeling → *estar*
 5. está — condition of an object → *estar*
 6. somos — nationality → *ser*
 7. está — location → *estar*
 8. es — permanent personality trait → *ser*
 9. estás — temporary state (ready) → *estar*
 10. está — condition → *estar*
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